

WHO WE ARE

Headwaters is a practitioner-built set of tools, financial models, and institutions for families and small communities who are done leaking wealth outward. We build for people who are ready to own their own ground, their own economy, and their own future — especially in rural and Indigenous territories. The work is shipped, not proposed. The voice is plain, dollar-honest, and never pitched.

THE THREE ETHICS

Care for Earth

The land sustains the people. The people are responsible for the land. Extraction without restoration is theft from future generations.

Care for People

Serve real needs fairly, starting with those most systematically excluded from ownership and self-determination.

Return of Surplus

Wealth generated in the watershed stays in the watershed. Surplus is reinvested into the system, not siphoned outward.

HOW THE SYSTEM IS ORGANIZED — ZONE LOGIC

Zone 0 — The Kitchen Table

The family, the household, the founding circle. Highest authority. Every system begins here and answers here.

Zone 2 — The Community

The people the practitioners serve. Their reality is the test of everything built in Zone 1.

Zone 4 — The Corridor

Partnerships, networks, and allied organizations. The place of replication and cross-pollination.

Zone 6 — The River

Our addition to the standard permaculture model — the outward flow layer: knowledge, replicable models, and tools other communities can pick up and run independently. We added Zone 6 because we are not just designing a place; we are designing replication. We own that deviation.

Zone 1 — The Practitioner's Field

Practitioners, operators, and builders doing daily work. Where tools live and get tested.

Zone 3 — The Market

Where tools and institutions connect with economic reality — stores, co-ops, vendors, buyers.

Zone 5 — The Wild

The external world — funders, governments, outside platforms, the broader economy. We observe it. We do not let it govern us.

THE HARD LINES

- We do not lease our sovereignty — not to governments, corporations, or ideologies.
- We do not trade privacy for convenience.
- We do not build dependency — every system must increase self-reliance, not create a new reliance on us or any outside institution.
- We do not dilute truth for broader appeal. The numbers are the numbers.
- We own the machine. We never become the machine's tenant.

HOW WE MAKE DECISIONS

- Every proposal, product, and partnership runs through five questions. All five must be answered honestly. A "no" on any of them stops the decision.
1. Does this strengthen the watershed or create a new leak?
 2. Does this increase ownership or create new dependency?
 3. Would we still do this if no outside money or approval was involved?
 4. Is this worthy of the next seven generations?
 5. Does it pass the Gord test? If Gord — a plain-spoken northern person who has seen enough promises fail — finds it suspicious or too clever, it doesn't ship.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR COLLABORATORS

If you are working with Headwaters as a funder, practitioner, or community partner, this is the operating system underneath everything we do together. We are not looking for partners who want to manage us, scale us, or soften our message for broader audiences. We are looking for people who understand that communities capable of feeding, housing, and governing themselves are good for everyone — and who are willing to work from that premise, plainly and honestly.